This is not a flattering depiction, but at the very least we can gather that Sumanguru was no more or less ruthless than Simon de Montfort, far to his north, or Genghis Khan, directing his operations far to the east.

The heartland of Ghana was much-coveted ground: watered by both rivers and sweet wells, says the Arab geographer al-Idrisi, with fish, elephants, giraffes, rice, and sorghum in abundance; so full of gold, writes the thirteenth-century cosmologist al-Qazwini, that it "grows in the sand of this country as carrots do in our land, and the people come out at sunrise to pluck the gold." Sumanguru did not hold his conquests easily. Not long after his destruction of the old Ghana government, he faced a challenge to his authority from another clan in the Malinke tribe; the Keita, to his southeast.[2]

The Keita, unlike the Sosso, were Muslim. They had traded up the Niger river valley, through the central trade route that led to Tunis, for generations, and Islamic beliefs had filtered back down to them along with the northern goods. They were also disinclined to submit to Sumanguru. Under their king Nare Fa Maghan, the Keita fought back. Before Nare Fa Maghan's death, sometime around 1217, Sumanguru's armies sacked the capital city of the Keita nine separate times. Each time, the Keita regathered themselves and again rebelled.[3]

When Nare Fa Maghan died, his oldest son inherited the rule of the Keita. Instead of continuing to fight, he decided to make peace with the aggressive enemy. Peace meant submission, but the new king was willing to pay the price; in addition, he handed over his sister in marriage to Sumanguru. For a time, the Sosso controlled almost all of the old Ghana territory.[4]

But the Keita remained restless, and it soon became apparent that the marriage treaty had been a ruse.

In the *Epic of Sundiata,* Sumanguru's bride tries to wheedle out of him, on their wedding night, the secret of his invulnerability on the battlefield: "What is it that can kill you?" she says, before she allows him to lay a hand on her. "If you do not tell me, you will not know me as a wife." (At this, Sumanguru's mother—unexpectedly close to hand—remarks, "Why would you spill your secrets to a one-night woman?" Soothing the old lady, Sumanguru promises to tell his new wife the secret once his mother is safely asleep.)

The secret, it turns out, is witchcraft; Sumanguru is a practitioner of the dark arts. Once she has learned this, the princess tells her groom that she's having her period and can't sleep with him after all; and the next morning she escapes home to tell her brothers her discovery. Armed with the materials for a hastily assembled spell against the sorcerer, her brother Sundiata—younger